The crackdown became more violent as live rounds became commonplace. At the Sule pagoda in downtown Rangoon, the crowds chanted “the army is the army of Aung San for the people, not to kill the people and the monks.” Eventually the military opened fire, killing first with rubber bullets and then with live ammunition. The most high-profile event was the execution of a Japanese video-journalist Kenji Nagai in Yangon. The military ordered the people to scatter or be shot. As the violence intensified, plain-clothed thugs working for the authorities participated in the violence against the protesters. The protesters remained peaceful throughout the bloody ordeal. The wounded received no medical attention.

By September 30, the regime was able to subdue the remaining protests. The crackdown was successful due to the work by the civilian thugs who were paid by the regime, as well as the combined forces of police and military. During the final days of September, nighttime raids of monasteries intensified. The destruction of religious property was significant. Numerous monks were ordered to de-robe and return to civilian life. Thousands of monks were detained in Yangon, Sittwe, and Kachin. During the military sweep, monks were physically abused, put through extended interrogation, and constantly humiliated. Tracking down the monks involved in the movement was made easier by the intense surveillance undertaken during the early days of the protests. The authorities resorted to detaining family and friends of wanted suspects. The once-vibrant Buddhist city of Yangon was especially hard hit and it was virtually emptied of clergy during the crackdown.

Authorities also took the drastic step of severing the Internet in Myanmar to ensure that Western media outlets could no longer receive information on the brutal suppression of the population. Detention centers were set up in major urban centers in Myanmar. Torture and human rights abuses were commonplace. The notorious Insein prison was used as one of the main detention and torture centers. Some of the documented abuses included inhumane conditions in the cells, severe beatings, sleep deprivation, and torture. Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch later documented the extent of the brutality. The curfews remained in place for several weeks as the regime continued to hunt down anyone and everyone involved in the Saffron Revolution.